

the Whirlwind, computers worked in batch mode—you keyed in instructions, went out for a stroll, and got back to find the results printed out. But the Whirlwind, originally intended as a flight simulator for US Navy bomber crews, could not have functioned in this way. Jay Forrester and his team at MIT's Lincoln Labs decided to use core memory (where magnetic ceramic rings are employed) as storage; this made the computer faster. It was also the first time video was used as an output device, in the form of a giant oscilloscope screen. Later versions were used as a backbone of SAGE, the air defence system of the US Air Force and also the first computer network. In 1956, a keyboard was integrated into the system.

August:

Computer Music

CSIRAC (Council for Scientific and Industrial Research Association Computer), which started functioning in Sydney in 1949, became the first computer ever to play music during its first public exhibition.

Upon inserting a punch card on which music was written in the standard notation, the computer would play it back through its loudspeaker. It was pretty crude, but still quite innovative in the early fifties.



A part of the CSIRAC computer

November: Business Apps

LEO I (Lyons Electronic Office I) became the first computer to run a business application. The computer was modelled on the Cambridge EDSAC, which was supported in part by J Lyons and Company, one of the UK's leading catering and food manufacturing companies. The LEO I was used for business data processing like inventory, payroll, costing, and delivery schedules—both in-